but some versions also tell of events after Rama's return to Ayodhya. (This bit appears to be have been added at a much later date.)

As one can see, the Ramayana is a journey from the Gangetic plains to the southern tip of India and on to Sri Lanka. It could be argued that the epic pre-dates geographical knowledge about South India and that the place-names were retro-fitted in later times to flow with the story. However, having visited some of the sites, I think this is unlikely. Take for instance Kishkindha, the kingdom of the monkeys. The site is across the river from the medieval ruins of Vijayanagar at Hampi. The terrain consists of strange rock-outcrops, caves with Neolithic paintings, and bands of monkeys scampering over the boulders.

It is such an evocative landscape that it is likely that Valmiki either visited it or had heard detailed descriptions of it from merchants plying the Dakshina Path or Southern Road. There are small details that seem too much of a coincidence to be purely imaginary. The lake of Pampa, where Rama first meets Hanuman, is indeed a beautiful place with lotuses in bloom and a multitude of birds, surrounded by a ring of rocky hills. Not far away from this site is a sloth bear reserve that recalls Jambavan, Hanuman's sloth bear friend. Archaeologists have found the remains of several Neolithic settlements in the area. It is easy to believe that this setting was once populated by a Neolithic tribe that used the monkey as a totem and gave rise to the legend.

The same can be said of the bridge from Rameswaram to Lanka. There exists a 30-km-long chain of shoals and sand-banks that links India to the northern tip of Sri Lanka. Whether one believes that these are the remains of Rama's bridge or the result of a geological process, it cannot be denied that this is a remarkable feature. The true scale of the bridge is best seen in a satellite or aerial photograph. Again, the composer of the epic clearly knew about it.

Moreover, we can tell a lot about how Iron Age Indians perceived the geographical extent of their civilization from the way Ravana is depicted. He is the villain of the Ramayana but is not presented as a Mlechha (or barbarian). He is very much an insider: a learned Brahmin and a worshipper